Organiser's Report, Charwell Challenge 19 March 2016 – The NZRA perspective

Grant Hunter

I reckon the hellishly hot conditions, considering we're into autumn, caught us all off our guard at Charwell Challenge. But the clear day enhanced the rugged Seaward Kaikoura backdrop and the glimpse of the distant ocean from high points in that (to most of us) 'mysterious frontier' called the Inland Road. It's a landscape unmatched in my rogaining experience. Under our feet were grassed hills with pockets of native forest and scrub, rock outcrops, and pesky scrub filled gullies which were only for the brave or reckless. The deceivingly high elevation of the start/finish leading to long and unseen drops into the valleys beyond – unseen until the reality of having to climb back up before close-off – led to some long climbs. The slower amongst us noticed that this is a stellar year for blackberries.

After Emma and Guy de Lacey had set the outer (and inner) dimensions of the check points I had considered extending from 6 to 8 hours (a view that Tim Farrant's performance more or less vindicated, below), but the long distance of travel for many would have made that too long a day.

I'm not going to dwell too much on results as I've not had time to study them. They can speak for themselves (6 hour results and 3 hour results), but a couple of highlights. Tim Farrant and Theo Wordworth scored 2250 out of possible 2730 points (you can examine their course at winner's route). To put some more meaningful numbers around that, they covered 34.4km with 2240m of height gain. Three weeks earlier, Tim was runner up in the 24 Hours NZ Rogaine Championship in Otago. It was great to see he and a number of other leading rogainers (the others especially in the veteran grade) supporting this regional initiative near Kaikoura. A great result also for Wellingtonians (I think), Sam Walton and Tom Wu. Both of these teams are Godzone-bound later this month. Our best wishes to you. Another highlight was the team from Kaikoura High school 'Four Ladies' (then three), Holly McKee with Tammy Smith-Kerr and Lynley Cormack, decisively leading the WO six-hour. Well done, ...you are an investment for our future!

Of about 170 participants in 60 teams, about 1/3 were from Christchurch and the remainder a good split between Kaikoura and Blenheim/Marlborough. A heartening feature was the number of family teams (eleven), with numerous under-15s racing around the landscape as well as adding bustle to the start/finish area.

Working in such a collaborative way with a local, largely rural community was both novel and successful. It means we could spread resources, but at some risk that the mixing of two cultures might lead to a new layer of challenge. That did not arise. Emma and Guy and Anne and I found working with Bin and Geoff Kennedy from one of three host farms and Kaikoura Suburban School on all aspects of the event an absolute pleasure, and likewise on the day working directly with a wider pool of school community and neighbours. Using the homestead lawn as a base for proceedings set a new standard for rogaine hosting that we don't expect to match into the future. Thank you all. To also acknowledge our own team – Bill Kennedy (no relation to our hosts) produced the map, Wayne Millow and Trevor Merrifield, and Emma handling entries, finances etc. Every event is a big job overall.

On Sunday, in equally testing temperatures, we recovered all but two check points (thank you Fiona Vetcher and family). And that is my excuse for not getting the checked results into a publishable form until Monday! Happy roaming.